



“Becoming CLEAR”

From a nonchalant teenager to authoring a book on Verilog at 25 and launching successful IPOs for startups on the US stock market, Rajeev Madhavan exemplifies how the right guidance can transform a life. This is the story of one of Silicon Valley’s most influential venture capitalists, as narrated to Yashasvini Razdan.

RAJEEV MADHAVAN

FOUNDER AND GENERAL PARTNER, CLEAR VENTURES

Growing up in Kochi, with a father who worked in Customs and a homemaker mother, Rajeev Madhavan was the youngest and only boy among three siblings. Pampered by everyone, young Rajeev’s dad, T.K. Madhava Panicker, was at the forefront of letting him prance and play cricket. However, his mother, Sathy Devi, was a tough taskmaster who ensured that none of her children slipped up on studies, maintaining a balance between pampering and control.

“My mother was a homemaker. She controlled the finances at home.

If I wanted to go play cricket and buy gear, my dad would let me, but my mum would not. She turned her family home into an apartment complex, sold some apartments, and kept some for rentals. Her business acumen was impeccable, but she probably never realised it,” recalls Rajeev, with admiration and awe for his mother’s tight grip and financial foresight.

A comical business

Rajeev did not spend any time concerning himself with the family’s finances or anything his parents did. His dad always found a way to fulfil

most of his wishes. His interests were limited to playing cricket, reading comic books, and overall mischief.

“I managed to get decent grades, but I never really worked hard on my studies, mostly because I was more interested in playing cricket and running around,” he laughs.

His raging passion for cricket was quelled by his mother, who, like a strict disciplinarian, ensured that Rajeev stuck to studying and achieving decent grades. Recalling an incident that ended very badly, Rajeev chuckles, “I was on the school cricket team. Just a week before the